God, If You're Really Out There

A Short Play

By Cynthia Riebesell

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God, If You're Really Out There

by **Cynthia Riebesell**

Characters:

Alana Grant (pronounced Ah-lah-nah)
Henry Grant
Pastor Jones (can be any gender)

Author's note: The piece you're about to read takes place in 2001 right after the 9/11 attacks. 50,000 employees worked in the World Trade Center buildings. Yet, when the Hijacked planes of the September 11th attack hit the towers, only 20,000 were busy working at their desks. Of those 20,000, only 3,500 died. People argue that it was God who spared all those other lives. So does this mean he was also responsible for the thousands of people who lost their lives? This one question haunted Alana's mind. After her husband's death in the 9/11 attack she begins to question the entire existence of god. While saying her husband's eulogy, she publically releases her isolated feelings and battles her faith in 'God, if you're really out there'.

Setting: After 9/11 attacks on New York City's Twin Towers, inside a church for the funeral of Henry Grant who was in the buildings.

……
Curtain Rises to:

(Outside the church door, Alana stands, dreading to make her steps through the door)

Pastor Jones: Alana? Are you ready?

(Alana glances at him, then looks forward, obviously looking like she's not ready, but does not say anything)

(Pastor Jones touches Alana's shoulder in a sentimental way, and walks into the church)

(Alana stands there and takes a very deep breath, then wipes her eye where a tear was falling down her cheek)

(Lights dim and lights rise to Pastor Jones standing at the church's podium at the front of the church.)

Pastor Jones: Today we gather to say our final goodbyes to an extraordinary man, Henry Grant. During this difficult time, God watches over us all, more than he ever has before. He's before us, easing all of the pain we feel in our hearts and souls. As each difficult day passes, he makes the next easier to bear. When I was 10 years old, my grandmother died. I hadn't really been exposed to death prior to that

event, so I didn't fully understand the situation. I remember my mother came up to me and said, "You're Grandma Jones is in a much better place now, honey." I didn't quite understand what she meant. Did she mean Grandma was on vacation? Was Grandma relocated to live in a more scenic place? I didn't think anything of it, until the day of her funeral arrived. I remember looking around at all the people in the church. They were hugging each other, with tears falling from their eyes. During that time, the biggest question in my mind was 'why?' Why were people sad? Why were they crying? However, like a bullet, I soon had my question answered. My grandmother's casket made me realize this 'better place' was referring to death. I stared at her casket, completely ignoring the pastor's sermon, wondering how death could mean a 'better place', and as if reading my mind, the pastor then said, "She is in a better place. With no pain, she rests in God's arms." A week ago, on September 11th, our country's people took hands and prayed for any kind of miracle. God has provided that miracle. He made Henry's pain go away, and made his trip to Heaven a painless journey. He's up there, in Gods arms, spreading his humor and witty persona among all the others whom we have lost in our lives. He is in a better place. With no pain, he rests in God's arms. Now, let us hear Alana's eulogy for her husband. ***(Looks at Alana and directs her forward by saying...)*** Alana.

(Alana gets up from her seat and walks to the front podium)

Alana: ***(awkwardly, unknowing how to greet the mass of people)*** Hello**. (She then looks down at her note cards which has her prepared speech written on it)(Takes a deep breath and smiles)** Henry and I met in high school during our sophomore year. He was on the debate team and I was on the school newspaper. I was writing an article about the state debate tournament, which Henry was competing in. I remember watching him debate with the other panel members. From his performance, I knew he would be the perfect person to interview about the tournament, so after the tournament, I managed to get an interview with him.
Flashback

Henry: You know, I've been on the debate team for a long time now, but never have I been bored. There's always something new to learn and there's never a moment when you can just relax with the impression that you've got this debate in the palm of your hand. I'm always at the balls of my feet, ready for that particular competitor to hit me with an argument, which I hadn't already thought of.

Alana: It sounds like you're really passionate about this activity, Henry. What else are you passionate about?

Henry: Well, don't laugh, but I am pretty damn passionate about Pac Man. I could play it for hours. You know, someday they are going to begin to tell us that we are too reliant on technology. That'll be the day! But really, did you know that there are over 200 Pac Man products?

Alana: Holy cow!

Henry: It's incredible! What about you? What are you passionate about?

Alana: Well since you admitted an embarrassing passion—

Henry: Hey! Mind your Pac-MANners! It's not embarrassing! It's… **(Pause)** Okay, yes, it's embarrassing…Well c'mon, what's yours?

Alana: Um, Well… I have about 56 posters of John Cusack all over my bedroom walls…

Henry: (laughs) Now THAT'S passion.

Alana: (giggles) I know.

Henry: Hey, do you wanna go get some pizza?

Alana: I'd love to.

Henry: Well come on then, I'll drive. Hey did you know that the creator of Pac Man generated Pac Man's shape after removing a slice from his large pizza?

End of Flashback

Alana: Somewhere in between the conversation involving his love for Pacman and mine for John Cusack, I realized he was the one for me... We dated through the rest of high school, practically glued to each other's hips. After we graduated, he proposed. We got married and moved out of Minnesota to live in the one place him and I always dreamed about, New York City. Being with him in the city that never sleeps was ironically like living in a dream with him. ***(Smiles and laughs, thinking about the memories)*** He was such a goofball. I remember this one time; we had been walking down the sidewalk on the corner of Broadway, arguing about something.

Henry: Alana, I'm sorry… I didn't mean what I said. Your mother isn't a witch. I'm sure her soup is wonderful. I highly doubt she adds poison to it whenever we're over at her house… **(Almost sarcastic)** C'mon Alana, stop walking away from me… **(Grabs Alana's arm)** I'm sorry.

Alana: No, Henry. You're always making jokes like that about her! It's not fair, you know she loves you and treats you wonderfully.

Henry: (under his breath) When you're in the room, yes.

Alana: I heard that, Henry! You're unbelievable.

(Keeps walking away, Henry doesn't move—instead he gets on his knees and begins singing)

Henry: BABY COME BACK! YOU CAN BLAME IT ALL ON ME!

(Alana turns around and rushes back to shut Henry up.)

Alana: Henry! What do you think you're doing?!

Henry: I WAS WRONG AND I JUST CAN'T LIVE WITHOUT YOU!

Alana: Stop singing right now! You're making a scene!

Henry: Forgive me then!

(Alana hesitates, Henry notices)

Henry: ANY KIND OF FOOL COULD SEE!

Alana: Ok, ok! **(Giggles)** But only if you stop singing!

End of Flashback

Alana: He was an awful singer… ***(Alana smiles real big, but slowly the smile fades and she sets down her note cards and begins to talk from her mind rather than her prepared speech)*** Talking about all these memories really makes me realize how much we've gone through…Now, he's gone.

For a week now, I've been sitting alone in our apartment. All of Henry's things sit in the exact same place he left them. His check book, which he had forgotten to take to work, sits on the kitchen counter. The shirt he had worn the night before the attack, hangs on the bedpost, and I can still smell his cologne on it. Even his half eaten pop tart still sits on the kitchen table. Everything I do, or see reminds me of him. I still feel as though he's going to come walking through that door at any moment but I know he never will. It's just me now. What have I got to believe in anymore? God? This guy, ***(points to cross behind her)*** on the cross? I mean, what has he done? ***(Pauses, controls temper)*** You know, I've never been that religious. Growing up, my family and I only attended church during the holidays. We never prayed. We never sang religious songs. But I still held the belief that there was something—anything--beyond this world. I believed that there was some kind of higher power, perhaps in some alternate universe. Not necessarily 'God', but just some kind of almighty being. But now, I don't know what to believe.

(beginning to tear up) We were having a great morning. I remember Henry being so excited about this idea that he was going to pitch to corporate.

Flashback

Alana: You've got this honey!

Henry: All the work is about to pay off! We'll finally be able to afford that apartment. We'll be able to start a family.

Alana: Let's not get ahead of ourselves, dear. You get through that meeting first.

Henry: I love you so much, Alana.

Alana: I love you too, Henry. Go get em'!

Henry: Ah, I love you, I love you, I love you! **(Hugs her tight)**

Alana: Go! You'll miss your meeting! I'll be here… And maybe when you get home tonight I'll finally have that 6th chapter finished in my book.

Henry: I'm so proud of you, baby. Today is going to be such a wonderful day, for the both of us!

Alana: (smiles and looks at Henry happily) Alright, honey. Get going. I love you! Good luck!

End of Flashback

Alana: He ran out the door, with such a happy bounce in his step. He kissed me goodbye and left for work.
If only I'd known it'd be the last time I'd ever see him. Ever feel him. Ever hear his voice. Couldn't 'God' have warned me? Somehow?
At about 8:30 AM, I got a call from Henry. He was telling me that corporate had loved his idea and they'd love to promote him to upper management. I remember thinking to myself; we're really going to make it. We have such a bright future ahead of us. We hung up, and literally no more than 20 minutes later, my phone began ringing again. It was Henry. However, the only sound I could hear was his breathing. It was slow and raspy, as if something was blocking his airway. I knew something was wrong, but before I could say anything, the sound of sirens began echoing from the streets. I looked out our apartment window and saw black smoke filling the sky. I turned on the TV to see if there was any news about where the smoke had been coming from and on the screen; the Twin Towers were being shown. The north tower had smoke flooding from it, as if there was a giant explosion, and that's when I realized

(pause as if visualizing it) it was Henry's office. I started screaming and begging for him to tell me if he was alright. I wanted him to assure me that he was safe and out of the building. But when he finally spoke, the only thing he said was,

Flashback

(Lights fade slightly; still able to see Alana)

Henry: ***(spotlight goes on Henry) (Alana also mouths these words but Henry actually says them)*** *Alana*, I love you.

(Henry's spotlight goes black, and Alana's light goes back to normal)

End of Flashback

Alana: But before I could respond, the line was cut, leaving only a dial tone left to be heard. I looked at the TV and saw the tower slowly beginning to fall. Floor, by floor, by floor. And I just stared, hoping that when I closed my eyes to blink, I'd open them to find all of this to be just a figment of my imagination…But I blinked and I blinked and nothing. This terrible, awful act of terrorism was reality. Henry, a kind, sweet, huge hearted man was the victim of such cruelty. I mean, how could someone so marvelous be killed by something so dreadful? ***(Sadness turns to anger)*** On the internet, I've read stories about how god delayed people from getting to work on time. Like for example, one lady's alarm clock didn't go off, so she wasn't at work when she was supposed to be. This one guy got a blister on his way to work, so he had to stop at a drugstore to buy a Band-Aid. And for another guy, it was his turn to bring the donuts, but I guess he got to eat them all by himself. I mean, if these stories really are Gods doing, then he prevented about 16,000 people from being to work on time, resulting in their lives being spared. Then why couldn't Henry have been one of those people? Where was God for Henry? **(Alana stares into space with tear soaked eyes, she begins to reflect)**

Flashback

Henry: Aren't those clouds just beautiful next to that blue sky?

Alana: Yes, they are. It's so easy to forget to look up every once in a while and when you finally do, it's like a breath of fresh air.

Henry: It's incredible. **(looks away from looking at the sky to face Alana)** Alright, I've got another one… if you had to choose would you travel to Malaysia or Romania?

Alana: (thinking…) mmmm…good one. I think Romania….Alright, my turn? Would you ever take your life to save someone else?

Henry: You know, sometimes I think about that. I think about whether or not I would run into a burning building to save someone… Or if I'd give my heart to you, if the doctors said you had very little time left. Yes, yes, I believe I would. Because I've already felt all the happiness in the world—living here, in this city, with the love of my life-- and knowing that I could give someone else a chance to keep living on in happiness, for some reason, makes me feel really good. **(sees the hurt reaction Alana has thinking about the small chance she might lose him on her face and says…)** But you know what; it's so peaceful, being here with you. Let's not think of a future where we're apart. Let's think of right now, under these clouds...

End of Flashback

Alana: (looking in the same direction she was with tears in her eyes and then faces her audience again) You know, if Henry were here, he'd probably scold me for only worrying about him. Knowing him, he probably would have wanted me to be happy that those thousands of lives were spared at all. And I am! But Henry isn't alive. And to be able to accept that doesn't seem humanly possible for me at this point. But until I find the courage to move on, I have but one last thing to say. A prayer. ***(Pause and look up to the sky as if talking to God)(Spotlight on Henry begins to go on and he looks at Alana)*** God? If you're really out there, I think you owe me a small favor. Just please, please tell Henry one thing for me. I love you too. ***(Alana keeps gaze towards the sky, as Henry smiles at her) (After a few seconds, lights go down)***

Curtain falls
End of play